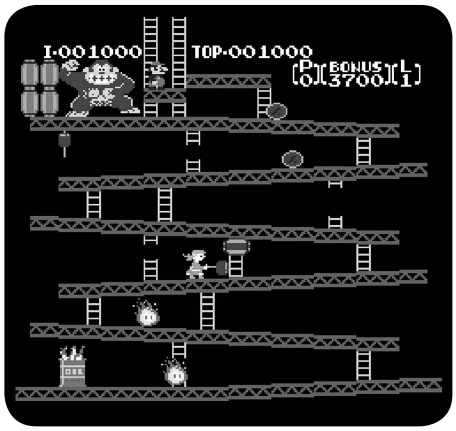


Video Games in Culture

The Cultural Position of Video Games

The Players



Donkey Kong (1981) was the first hit game for Nintendo and the first to feature Mario, later to become a star himself

This chapter will map the cultural position of video games; that is, we will look at video games as producers of meaning, both for society in general and for the people who play them. Games are a part of a complex cultural system as well as generators of a specific player culture. When you see how *Fortnite* with its dance moves and emotes has made its way into dance classes and mainstream media, you know game culture have become omnipresent—and that separating games from society and culture is harder than ever.

Researchers challenge the idea of the "magic circle" separating games from real life, as described earlier in this book. Celia Pearce has put it beautifully, saying that the "magic circle is more porous than previously believed."[1] Such work has mainly involved observation of MMORPGs, in which, as Geoff King and Tanya Krzywinska say:

> Gameplay does not exist in a vacuum, any more than games do as a whole. It is situated instead, within a matrix of potential meaning-creating

> frameworks. These can operate both at a local level, in the specific associations generated by a particular episode of gameplay and in the context of broader social, cultural and ideological resonances.[2]

This is what we will deal with in this chapter. In the first section, we address the cultural status of video games (as lowbrow, escapist entertainment), and consider how the mass media portrays them. The second section is about the people who play video games and the game communities they create.

THE CULTURAL POSITION OF VIDEO GAMES

No cultural form exists in isolation; rather, it is integrated within a complex system of meanings shaped by society and its institutions. Compared to other cultural forms, such as literature, the medium of the video game is a new member of this fascinating ecology. It is certainly true that the history of cultural media shows an almost instinctive skepticism leveled at new media.[3] It has been true of radio, it has been true of movies, and it has certainly been true of television, which has long fought against the perception that its role was to entertain rather than to enlighten. Many issues factor into the battle for cultural acceptance that most new media must fight. Some are formal, for example, a strong visual basis usually does not help, as this hints that the medium may be one suited for the illiterate; others are social, for instance, the perceived intentions of the producers. Media that are seen as primarily market-driven fare poorly in the quest for acceptance as a culturally valuable activity.

Expressions of taste or distaste about a new medium are not just objective judgments, even though they may appear so; they are probably also strategic or power-related. French sociologist Pierre Bourdieu,[4] opposing the commonly held idea that taste is an individual matter, argued that taste is an altogether social phenomenon. It is a means to establish boundaries by signaling one's membership of a certain social group. Those with power will praise their own tastes in music and books and cultural media in general, and will tend to label other cultural forms as uncivilized or otherwise problematic. In contrast, marginalized groups have historically coalesced around certain activities (or cultural expressions) in order to establish a counterculture that prizes distinct values and tastes. Video games are one of the most potent examples of a novel cultural object; not surprisingly, they too have been immersed in such battles.

Cultures around the world tend to distinguish between forms of expression that are or are not intrinsically worthwhile. In Western societies, for example, painting, literature, and sculpture are traditionally considered more dignified, more worthy of careful attention, than television and games (electronic or otherwise). During the middle part of the twentieth century, however, the traditional hierarchy was challenged by artists who drew upon objects and images from pop culture. This trend was exemplified by the pop art movement. A foundational example of this is Andy

Warhol's series of portraits of Marilyn Monroe. The boundaries between high and low culture were decisively blurred, and to the delight of some and the horror of others, Western culture has been unable fully to separate the two ever since.

Meanwhile, theoretical and scientific developments pushed in the same direction. The rising discipline of media studies, particularly work inspired by semiotics and ethnography, challenged the idea that certain media or genres were inherently better than others. One such movement was the widely influential cultural studies school, which examined contemporary phenomena—often from a neo-Marxist perspective—to understand their meaning and relationship to power structures and the wider culture. Such approaches were typically guided by the beliefs that all cultural phenomena could be "read"—that is, interpreted—and that no particular type should be privileged. The movement also coincided with a growing number of empirical studies that showed how media users appropriated all types of media products for their own purposes and often used (or interpreted) them in ways not necessarily connected with the type or class of products.[5]

All these developments have served to blur, but not erase, the distinction between high culture and pop culture. Games are still categorized within the latter—and still lower—sphere. Many of us, scholars and gamers alike, have argued that games are underrated as an art form, and that games only lose out in comparison to other arts because the criteria are not suited to their particular qualities. Such arguments tend to emphasize the arbitrariness of distinctions between art and nonart, and expose the unfairness of denying the status of art to a form of expression just because it provides entertainment and aspires to a mass market.[6] Whether something is actually art can never definitively be settled through analysis and debate. The question is more significant in terms of the battle for legitimacy. It is at once meaningless—since it merely depends on our definition of art—and of great practical importance, as the answer has consequences for everything from the establishment (and relative importance) of academic departments, to government regulation of the video game industry (by, for example, censorship through ratings), to the cultural obligations of that industry—which conceivably will develop in different ways depending on whether it is a part of the establishment or if it is denied legitimacy. If nothing else, the question is at least an intriguing one, since today's games are the subject of heated argument over what they mean and how we should feel about them. But how do games communicate meaning? What is it about them that is so contemptible?

Games as Cultural Forms

Video games are made to entertain, but this doesn't prevent them from being "means for creative expression," as Mary Flanagan puts it.[7] Like other media, games can have different functions and expressive intentions, side by side with entertainment. It is also possible to design games for "artistic,

political, and social critique or intervention,"[8] linking games to larger cultural issues.

However, typically cultural critics see games exclusively as representational objects, and do not take their procedural characteristics into account. Many who have looked at games as producers of meaning in the areas of ethics (especially the issue of representation of violence) or gender studies have ignored the dynamic nature of games.

For example, a study from 1995 looked at representations of women in the most popular 33 games at the time. These portrayals ran the gamut from sex symbols or prizes, to victims of male power, to heroes and action characters. The study also considered the use of violent themes in the games. The verdict was that the most common depiction of women in games was that of "damsel in distress":

> In one example, *The Adventures of Bayou Billy* (1989), the beginning of the video game shows a woman in a low-cut, red dress. This woman has large, well-rounded breasts. A man is holding her and has a knife placed at her throat. Apparently, this man has kidnapped Annabelle and Billy's mission is to save her.[9]

In the games analyzed, aside from victim or sex object, all the female characters had insignificant roles (or very stereotypical ones, in the case of villains). This is not untrue, but instead of looking at how these representations combine with the mechanics of the games, and what actions and choices are afforded to the player, the study hurries to conclude that engaging with this kind of representation is harmful to children of both sexes, "since they will internalize these expectations and accept the idea that women are to be viewed as weak, as victims, and as sex objects,"[10] without reference to any empirical material that would support this claim. There is nothing wrong with taking an exclusively analytical stance, but the formal analysis is also partial, so that the conclusion rests on very thin grounds. It may be that it is correct, but we cannot know for sure if the *playing* of the games is not considered.

An even clearer example of this representational bias—of failing to consider video games in their specificity as a media form—is a study by Urbina Ramirez and colleagues,[11] who through the analysis of covers of games, and without actually playing them, conclude that games promote a subordinate and stereotypical position of women.[12] Video games are seen as representational media *only*. This can be very problematic in a cultural form that is so much more than representation.

We could, for example, make a content analysis of the character of April Ryan in *The Longest Journey*. We would immediately be placed on our guard by and comment critically on her tight clothes, full breasts, large, innocent eyes, and sensuous mouth; it would be easy to conclude that she was a sex object and a passive figure.



Figure 6.1 April Ryan in *The Longest Journey*, on the way to her next destination

However, this would be far from the truth. April Ryan is an independent and resourceful character, who is not only the protagonist of the game but also makes decisions that can alter the fate of the world, and engages in dangerous action without depending on men. The point is that exclusive use of content analysis to evaluate the cultural role of video games will never give us a full and fair picture.

Cultural critics would do well to study those authors who have developed specific theories about how video games communicate ideas, including Ian Bogost,[13] Noah Wardrip-Fruin,[14] and Mary Flanagan,[15] among others. All these authors, inspired more or less explicitly by Janet Murray, insist on procedurality as one of the basic properties of the computer, and by extension of video games. Bogost proposes the term **procedural rhetoric**, defined as "the art of persuasion through rule-based representations and interactions rather than the spoken word, writing, images, or moving pictures."[16] He adds that "videogames are computational artifacts that have cultural meaning *as* computational artifacts."[17] As critics, we need to learn to read these processes, and also to understand how players find meaning in procedural work. In other words, it is not only how games *look* but also what we can *do* in and with them that produces meaning.

Procedural rhetoric: The art of persuasion through rule-based representations and interactions (typically in games) rather than the spoken word, writing, images, or moving pictures.

In order to illustrate this, Bogost analyzes a myriad of different games, ranging from small, politically motivated games like *September 12th* to commercial products like *Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas* or *America's Army*, produced by the US Army. It is the latter we will use to show how procedural rhetorics work. *America's Army* is a multiplayer first-person shooter created

specifically as a recruiting and communication tool, and released for free on the Internet. It was very successful, especially in the United States, and was hailed as extremely realistic, reflecting both the physical constraints of combat as well as the rule system of the army. Bogost draws attention to two game mechanics that, for him, reveal the underlying ideology of the game: the honor system and the enemy threat. All characters in the game can earn honor points by following orders and respecting the chain of command; if characters behave inappropriately, for example, by pointing a weapon at a superior or swearing, they will be punished. It takes a lot of time and effort to build up honor statistics, so that losing a character would be very frustrating for the player. Thus, the more honor points gained, the more interested players are in following orders. Bogost, who also takes into account the perspective of the game designers,[18] explains:

> Army success entails the selfless execution of tasks that have been handed down from a higher authority, completed without question or reservation. These tasks, like real US Army missions, are decontextualized from geopolitics. Reward comes not from service completed in the conscious interest of a conflict, but from service completed in the absence of political circumstance. The US Army recruit, one learns from *America's Army*, is an apolitical being.[19]

This is reinforced by the procedural rhetoric of enemy threat. In *America's Army*, players fight each other in small groups on opposing sides, but both teams believe they are the good guys. "The perceptual interchangeability of enemy and soldier underscores the contemporary American assumption that matters of military conflict are commutative; that is to say, one global, even transcendental situation guides both sides of the conflict."[20] Opposition is decontextualized, and perceptual equivalence means that the only explanation for the enemy's behavior must be wickedness.

As Wardrip-Fruin observes, examining the expressive qualities of computer processes helps us to understand "the aspects of works that are not apparent on the surface."[21] It is vital to us as citizens of the twenty-first century to be able to understand complex software systems and how they shape our understanding. An appreciation of the procedural expression capabilities of video games will also allow us to extract ethical meaning from games, as the work of Miguel Sicart eloquently demonstrates.

For Sicart, video games are moral objects that make players (who are moral beings) reflect on their actions. Ethical or unethical play design is not a question of the game being more or less sophisticated in its representation of the world; rather, it is a matter of how the game rules shape the moral responsibility of its players. An ethically relevant game forces "the player to face ethical dilemmas."[22] Video games shouldn't take the moral decision-making power away from the player; a game like *XIII*, where shooting a policeman immediately prompts the "game over" screen, doesn't give players a chance to make their own decisions and experience the

consequences. In contrast, a reviled game like *Manhunt*, which forces the player to commit murders, can be, paradoxically, more illuminating from an ethical perspective, because it

> is actually designed to make the player enact an unethical experience, showing that there is no fun in committing these acts, but rather mirroring the lack of morals and the desperate situation of the main character in the fictional game world.[23]

Sicart's vision of players as moral beings allows them to follow their own morality and to "decide which values, practices and discourses are morally desirable."[24] From this perspective, players are not dupes who consume violent content; instead they are empowered to choose both the games they play and their playing strategies.

Public Perception of Games

Despite the work presented in the last section, there aren't many cultural critics who deal with games in their own terms, as procedural forms capable of generating new kinds of expression. For most, play and games equal entertainment, one of the most suspect cultural categories. Entertainment plays a crucial—and much-debated—role in contemporary life. It is often considered synonymous with escapism, which carries very strong negative connotations, since it is associated with an unhealthy flight from reality through means such as drugs.

But we could also adopt a wider notion of escapism, one that includes any human activity not immediately geared toward survival. In this definition, video games are certainly escapist but so too is literature and indeed all of the fine arts. The time that is "left over" in our struggle for survival can—and perhaps should—be filled with another reality, one that is more pleasurable and offers relief from the difficulties of living.[25]

The psychologist Andrew Evans differentiates between escapist activities as passive (such as watching bad television) or active (such as gardening). Games would belong to the active category (to return to Sutton-Smith: the rhetoric of "play as the imaginary"[26]). Evans does not consider games a negative activity, since the healthy or unhealthy quality of escapism does not depend on the activity itself but on its context and the way it is performed. (In principle, any kind of escapism can become an addiction.) He considers games a necessity, both for mankind as a species and for children in their psychological development, and looks at the future of advanced console gaming with positive curiosity regarding new possibilities for simulation and what they could offer us.[27]

In the same vein, Mary Flanagan insists that play has always had subversive qualities as well as purely entertaining ones. She draws on examples of Victorian subversive doll play practices, such as "reskinning," "unplaying," and "rewriting," which are strategies for social resistance.[28] In her book

Critical Play, she analyzes many cases of games and artifacts that engage players in activities that make them question different aspects of human life, from the pleasures of familiarity afforded by the video game *The Sims* to artistic interventions like *OUT*, which turns playing *America's Army* into a live urban performance with an antiwar agenda. The main point is that the nature of games as rule-oriented objects makes them specially geared toward activism. Art, games, and an active critical view of society are thus naturally connected:

> Due to the systemic nature of both the product and the process, game makers use particular repeatable processes, or methods. Like activists, game designers also follow an overall scheme of investigation or research, creating processes to address specific concerns and ideas. In addition, the creation of rules of operation makes interesting constraints to provoke innovation in both the designer's process and the player's role.[29]

However, for most other critics, and certainly for the mass media in general, video games are still consistently considered unsophisticated in their form, problematic in their content, the cause of health problems from obesity to addiction, and implicated in amorphous cultural fears—for example, the seemingly ever-present scourge of antisocial, aggressive teenagers. The first video games raised few cultural eyebrows—perhaps because so few people ever played them, or perhaps because their few pixels were so abstract that they had little emotional impact. But it wasn't long before this new form of entertainment raised suspicion. The year 1976 marked the entry of video games into America's culture wars; as seen earlier, *Death Race*—with its goal of running over tiny human-like figures—sounded the first alarm, sparking a media outcry that led to the banning of the game.[30]

From early on reporters and commentators expressed concern over the detrimental effects of gaming, whether physical or moral.[31] Reports in the US popular media in the early 1980s often appeared fascinated with the growing subculture of gaming. For the following three decades, the concerns surrounding games have been remarkably consistent, with few developments.

Concern over violence in games, and the endless argument over whether computerized violence can spill over into violence in the real world, has repeatedly spurred academic and cultural research (see Chapter 9 on "Video Games and Risks"). The results have further fed public discussion, from government think tanks, to outraged parents, to kids themselves.[32]

In their short history, video games have been connected to a wide variety of (often contradictory) effects. As one editorial in the *British Medical Journal* mentioned, game play has been connected with aggression and addiction, while "case studies have reported adverse effects of playing video games, including auditory hallucinations, enuresis, encopresis, wrist pain, neck pain, elbow pain, tenosynovitis, hand-arm vibration syndrome, repetitive strain injuries, peripheral neuropathy, and obesity."[33] Meanwhile, news

media regularly report that games have been linked with positive effects like improved hand-eye coordination.

Given that even early arcade games—with their primitive graphics and barely human protagonists—sparked full-fledged controversy, there is no direct link between a game's realism or content and the level of cultural concern. Nevertheless, most of these flare-ups have occurred in the last couple of decades, and are often tied to particularly violent titles. Controversy became especially intense in the United States in the early 1990s. This was just when the console producer Sega sought to distinguish themselves from Nintendo by publishing much more provocative games. While Nintendo's games were family-friendly, Sega tried to appeal to older audiences by betting on adult themes and graphic violence. A number of publishers were more than happy to comply, and launched games that seemed bound to cause alarm.

Mortal Kombat, in particular, was released for the Sega console in 1992[34] (see Chapter 4) and quickly came to symbolize the trend toward ruthless on-screen violence. Acclaim, who released the game for the Sega Genesis/Megadrive and the Super Nintendo, were told by both Sega and Nintendo to tone the game down; but Sega allowed players, through the use of codes, to unlock the game's full-scale violence. According to Gagne:

> Newspaper articles described *Mortal Kombat* as "offering children exciting new ways to maim, dismember, and murder unsavory opponents in a sadistic martial-arts tournament" in which "it is considered a mark of success . . . to rip the head and spine out of an opponent and wave it in the air while the blood flows to the ground."[35] With such stirring imagery, it was only natural for parents to be concerned about video games as more than a thief of a child's attention.[36]

America was thus primed for upset over *Night Trap* (1992), a horror game released a few months earlier and inspired by the already disreputable slasher film genre. It raised such controversy that it was removed from some US stores in 1993. Moving beyond a reliance on graphics, the game actually used full-motion video to bring to life the player's efforts to save a group of female college students trapped in a lakeside house full of vampires. The game contained both scantily clad screaming young women and lots of blood, so it was a sure recipe for scandal.

The wake left by these and other troubling games led all the way to Washington, DC, and in July 1994 the US Congress debated how to respond. The result was the creation of the Entertainment Software Rating Board (ESRB),[37] established by (what is now called) the Entertainment Software Association[38] at the prompting of Congress. Since 1994, the ESRB has rated every video game published in the United States. The anonymous raters[39] assign a game one of six age ratings, from "Early Childhood" (suitable for age three and older) to "Adults Only" (18 years and older), as well as a series of content descriptors (there are more than 30) such as "Drug Reference,"

"Nudity," or "Strong Language." A similar system, Pan European Games Information (PEGI),[40] exists in Europe with aims and procedures comparable to those of the ESRB. The US rating system, in particular, has been the subject of some controversy, as its methods and rulings have become issues in the continuing debate about how we define violence and immorality. A regular complaint is that any suggestion of sex will cause games to be rated as Adults Only, while games with high doses of violence will receive lower ratings.[41]

As an illustration of this, we can look at the cultural outrage around the *Grand Theft Auto* series. The games from *Grand Theft Auto III* onward have all courted controversy because of the player character's criminal and violent behavior toward police and others. After its 2001 release, *Grand Theft Auto III* was criticized for its focus on crime (carjacking in particular); in 2002 *Vice City* became infamous for a game mechanic allowing the player to have (off-screen) sex with prostitutes. Afterwards, the player could assault the prostitute and steal her money. Though the mechanic was optional, such actions were made possible by the game, and arguably encouraged, since the player received a health bonus by having sex. Unlike players, critics failed to recognize the ironic and satirical humor integral to these games. Their game worlds were inspired by gangster movies and, particularly in the case of *Vice City*, made abundant use of pop culture. To the initiated, the game played like a living pastiche of TV cop shows from the 1980s. Though these sources of inspiration had long been in the cultural mainstream, these video games (and perhaps the industry as a whole) were still too new, and too discomforting, to be accepted.

Two years later, *Grand Theft Auto: San Andreas*—inspired by California gang life in the early 1990s—came under attack in a case curiously similar to the *Mortal Kombat* scandal almost 15 years earlier. The game contained a sex minigame that, even though not accessible in the published version, could be unlocked by installing the PC **mod** *Hot Coffee*.[42] While the developer, Rockstar North, contended that installing the mod that brought the content into the game was a violation of the user's agreement (and that Rockstar therefore couldn't be held responsible), the fact remained that the content was present in both the PC and console versions of the game. This prompted the ESRB in 2005 to re-rate the game as Adults Only, and some stores to remove it from their shelves. Rockstar hurried to produce a version without the *Hot Coffee* content, and recovered the game's "Mature" rating but lost money in the process.[43] Later that year, high-profile politicians including Senators Hillary Clinton and Joe Lieberman used this example in their call for further regulation of computer game content. More recently, *Grand Theft Auto V* attracted its fair share of controversy due, among other things, to an interactive torture sequence.

Mod (modification): A piece of software that modifies the appearance and/or rules of an existing game. Mods are often made and published by enthusiastic players.

Though public reactions to video games arise, as we have seen, due to a host of factors, the role of media panic is essential. In using the term "media panic," we are referring to the public's reaction (through traditional media such as newspapers or television) to the form or content of new media;

typically, the novelty is seen as inherently dangerous for people (readers, viewers, or players, depending on the medium) who are thought incapable of distinguishing fantasy from reality.

In 2004 the British tabloid press caused an outcry over a 17-year-old boy who was allegedly obsessed with the game *Manhunt*, and who killed a friend in a manner similar to that of the sadistic murders of the game. Reports seemed to cement the link between the game and the murder, dabbling in psychiatry, speculating about the troubled boy's motivations, and positing a clear cause-and-effect relationship between the two. It later turned out that it was the victim, not the murderer, who was a player of the game.[44]

In 2011, the Norwegian Anders Breivik killed 77 people in a bombing in Oslo and shooting on the island of Utøya. In the uproar following this horrific episode, several media outlets picked up on the fact that Breivik, in a manifesto supposedly written by him before the mass murder, had admitted to having played video games. He allegedly used *Call of Duty* to train his combat skills, and *World of Warcraft* as "a useful cover story to explain the time one is actually spending plotting attacks."[45] Immediately several stores in Norway removed the offending games, plus a few other "violent games," from their shelves, out of respect for the dead.[46]

There are countless examples in the media of alleged links between video games and extreme violence: the Columbine High School massacre is regularly invoked. Few media outlets resist the urge to make this connection, even though the perpetrators typically have serious psychological and social problems that predate their engagement with whichever cultural medium they favor. Michael Moore plays with the absurdity of media panic in his film *Bowling for Columbine* (2002), in which he wonders whether the fact that the two teenage murderers regularly went bowling should be linked to their crimes as well.

The scientific evidence linking video game (or other media) consumption to real-world violence is highly contested (we'll discuss this link further in Chapter 9). As Henry Jenkins puts it:

> If video game violence was an immediate catalyst, we would have difficulty explaining why none of the shootings involving teens have occurred in movie theaters or video arcades where the direct stimulus of game playing would be most acute. Instead, these murders have tended to occur in schools and we need to look at real-world factors to discover what triggers such violence. Media activists strip aside those careful qualifications, claiming that the computer games are "murder simulators" teaching our children to kill.[47]

Dmitri C. Williams has analyzed the representation of video games in major American news magazines.[48] His results show that media discourse on video games is plagued with misconceptions and frequently vilifies the games themselves. These attacks have little to do with video games per se, Williams argues; rather, they reflect basic conservative fears about new media, and

even show the same historical progression of anxiety that other media before them have suffered: "first were fears about negative displacement, then health, and then antisocial behaviors like aggression and violence."[49] He notes that "at the same time as games were drawing the ire of conservative society, they were also used as a means of reinforcing social norms and power relations. This was particularly evident for gender and age."[50] Women players and older players are ignored by the media, so that the media picture of a gamer is still tied to the negative image of the male antisocial teenager.

As this section has shown, video games occupy a contested cultural niche in today's Western societies. We have been suspicious of play and entertainment since Plato. The dominant influence of the Protestant work ethic, among many other things, has made it difficult for adults to justify play and games. Video games have inherited this prejudice, along with all of the other suspicions that are heaped upon new media.

On the other hand, video games have also become more established as a cultural form with a strength of its own, and continue to slide into the mainstream. The number of people who have never played a video game—from first graders to retirees—seems to be dwindling inexorably.[51] Children and adults alike are drawn to video games. And in the midst of these conflicting assumptions—about what we should do with our time and what we want to do, between whether games have a purpose or whether they just expose us to danger—the video game has become a cultural object of importance. Not unlike the many-sided die of the old *Dungeons & Dragons* games, video games yield many answers, depending on how you look at them, and reveal many different things about us as people.

But who are gamers and why do they play? This question is addressed in the next section.

THE PLAYERS

There has been a growing tendency within computer game studies to look beyond an exclusively formal understanding of games (as systems of rules) and adopt a situated play approach instead. The question is not so much "What Is a game?" as "How is this game played?" Studying gamers at play illuminates the ways games operate as interactive objects and how they engender meaning on multiple levels. As Jason Rutter and Jo Bryce put it, this approach moves "away from any basic assumption that digital games have a meaning or form that can be discovered through applying the right analytical cipher to the appropriate game code in a manner removed from social, economic and political contexts." Games are "cultural artefacts which are given value, meaning and position through their production and use."[52]

Why Play?

Most of the people reading this book are, like the authors, intrigued by the world of video games, if not players themselves. But we should not forget the

befuddled spouses, not to mention the aggravated fathers and the protective mothers. Because these people ask a very important question: what are you doing spending all that time staring at a screen? And they have a point. Although some people play video games very casually, others seem to live for little else. They play with an all-consuming passion. They spend hours tucked away in their rooms or clustered in Internet cafés, punching buttons and staring at a screen, gripped by the unending possibilities of video games.

So what is it that makes this activity so fascinating? A number of psychologists have tried to answer this question. Juan Alberto Estallo has compiled several explanations based on reinforcement theory, or the boost in self-esteem felt by those who become good at playing. Moreover, players assign symbolic value to the games they play, so that they find their own subjective rewards in the act of playing. Estallo is aware that any self-esteem boosting activity is prone to provoke addiction in certain kinds of people, but he rejects that video games per se are a cause of sociopathologies. He actually stresses the positive qualities of video game players, such as a high level of creativity and extroversion, and a heightened capacity for learning.[53]

Estallo's theories are borne out by the empirical experience of the authors Sue Morris and Talmadge J. Wright, who have written about first-person shooters. In Morris's *Online Gaming Culture*, she argues that some video games provide a degree of "authorship," meaning creativity and autonomy, which is lacking in many other available forms of recreation (as we will see later with regard to the modding community).[54] Wright, Boria, and Breidenbach have studied player communication and conclude that it "can both reproduce and challenge everyday rules of social interaction while also generating interesting and creative innovations in verbal dialogue and non-verbal expressions."[55] Video games would thus allow players to escape alienation in different ways, and to engage in a kind of activity that goes beyond consumerism.

Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi's book *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience* has often been applied to explain the joy people find in video games. His concept of **flow** describes a state of concentration and satisfaction that a person experiences when performing an activity—anything from playing a musical instrument to climbing a mountain—she enjoys very much, and that becomes an "optimal experience." Flow usually refers to activities that fall outside daily routines, and include a certain sense of playfulness. People will achieve it through completely different activities, depending on their preferences. The optimal experience is "an end in itself. Even if initially undertaken for other reasons, the activity that consumes us becomes intrinsically rewarding."[56] The experience of flow is characterized by the following elements of enjoyment:

Flow: The flow state is described as the feeling of optimal experience. It is felt when we feel in control of our own fate and have a sense of exhilaration and enjoyment.

- A challenging activity that requires skills (not something spontaneous but goal-oriented and with rules)
- The merging of action and awareness (attention is totally absorbed by the activity)

- Clear goals and feedback
- Concentration on the task at hand (forgetting about everything else)
- The paradox of control (the sense of exercising control in difficult situations where your abilities are pressed to the limit)
- The loss of self-consciousness
- The transformation of time (either time passes very quickly, or at a key moment a second can be experienced as lasting for a long time).[57]

Csikszentmihalyi suggests that in order to turn an activity into a flow experience, the first step is to make it a game. He suggests that a person establishes her own rules, objectives, and rewards and lets herself be absorbed by a powerful goal. But this goal will only work if it is balanced with the person's abilities: the task should not be too difficult or we will experience anxiety, nor too easy or we will get bored. The reward of flow is the ability to lose oneself and experience ecstasy, understood as a total detachment from the world outside the activity, so that the actor becomes the event.

The theory of flow can help to explain why people enjoy playing video games: games often adapt to the expertise of the player,[58] so there is a match between ability and goal, and anyone who has tried to get the attention of someone immersed in a game knows how the player can lose awareness of everything outside it.

But flow is at the same time such a general concept that it could explain any other activity equally well. The theory ultimately does not offer a specific explanation as to why video games are fun to engage with—why don't players seek flow through other available activities?[59]

In her book *Reality Is Broken*, Jane McGonigal presents an interesting variant of the psychological explanations for why we play. For her, "games are providing what reality cannot."[60] Games make us happy despite being hard work because we prefer rewarding interaction to being entertained passively. With games, flow can be experienced immediately.[61] She identifies a series of intrinsic rewards afforded by games, which is worth quoting at length:

> First and foremost, we crave *satisfying work*. [This] means being immersed in clearly defined, demanding activities that allow us to see the direct impact of our efforts.
>
> Second, we crave *the experience, or at least the hope, of being successful*. We want to feel powerful in our own lives and show off to others what we're good at.
>
> Third, we crave *social connection*. We want to share experiences and build bonds, and we most often accomplish that by doing things that matter together.
>
> Fourth and finally, we crave *meaning*, or the chance to be a part of something larger than ourselves. We want to feel curiosity, awe, and wonder about things that unfold on epic scales.[62]

The chapters of McGonigal's book are organized around these rewards. For her, engaging with games is about happiness hacking; life is hard and difficult, and games make it better. This is an attractive argument: it would be fantastic if games were the cure for all angst and all the difficulties of life. Unfortunately, in contrast to the grandness of this vision, McGonigal's examples seem rather mundane, for instance, a points game to turn household chores (like cleaning the bathroom) into something fun that motivates all housemates to take part. Even without going into the issue of gamification, it seems that both the bleakness of the world and the benefits of game-like activities (like engaging in crowdsourcing or collaborative projects) are overstated. Still, it is an insightful work that sheds optimistic light on how games engage players, and on the possibilities of games as a cultural form.

Sherry Turkle offers another direction of inquiry in her book *Life on the Screen*, an examination of simulated identity and interactions in "inhabited" game worlds.[63] She looks at textual MUDs as spaces where people have a chance to experiment with different identities. Ultimately, the medium allows us to realize—and directly experience—the notion that there is no unified self. Reality is just another window, like the window of a computer screen; what one experiences online has real-life implications and consequences. This is seen as something positive, as Turkle insists on the illuminating and even curative properties of this kind of play, even though she acknowledges that some players experience a dangerous fragmentation of their identity from too much play. Her work on MUDs is certainly relevant to all social game worlds where players adopt a fictive identity, and is a powerful testimony to the profound ways that video games can influence one's sense of self.

Dennis D. Waskul has also dealt with the symbolic boundaries between person, player, and persona that players build in role-playing games, and comes to the conclusion that "boundaries inevitably implode as person, player, and persona blend and blur into an experience that necessarily involves all three."[64] Waskul's essay appears as part of a collection, one of two edited by Williams,[65] which together offer valuable perspectives on how games are linked into the lives of players, and how in-game relationships with other players are an important playing motivation. Torill Mortensen, for example, argues that in games a great deal of pleasure is derived "from a gaming environment that permits personal influence, social interaction and development in relation to other players, not just in relation to the game."[66]

As we can see, people also play games because of the emotions they elicit. Here, the work of Aki Järvinen[67] and Olli Leino[68] springs to mind as some of the most significant contributions to the area.

Inspired by cognitive science, Aki Järvinen links emotions in games to the particular pleasures offered by staged pretense. An interesting implication of his understanding of game emotions is that game systems

> not only elicit emotions from players, but also lead them to predict their and fellow players' future emotions during the game. Gaming encounters,

> thus, presents an "emotional huddle" of sorts, and in its center there lies a game system as an agent, the actions of which are predicted as well—through trial and error of scripts and schemas that are channelled through game mechanics to the game elements and system behaviour.[69]

Leino also makes game emotions dependent on gameplay conditions, in order to find the specificity of games as objects:

> What is common with all players' experiences with single-player computer games, even those with an open-ended "simulation game" like *Sim City 4*, is that they can be described in terms of negotiating the gameplay condition in one way or another. This applies also to "transgressive play," those players' actions which are "symbolic gesture[s] of rebellion against the tyranny of the game" and attempt to break out from the role of "ideal player" implied by the game. . . . Consider for example constructing a city in *Sim City 4* just to raze it by refusing to call in the fire brigade when an accidental blaze breaks out involves negotiating the gameplay condition. Describing the emotions arising from both "constructing" and "razing" the city (including all the smaller-scale projects involved) as meaningful and rational equally necessitate appealing to the gameplay condition as the criteria."[70]

Multiplayer games in particular can create a whole palette of "social feelings" in the gamer; a player might run the emotional gauntlet during a game, feeling anything from rage to joy to betrayal, all because of the trials and tribulations of his on-screen persona. These emotions—even the negative ones—can offer a powerful incentive to keep playing. Jonathan Baron has explored the emotions attached to this kind of game, examining how these simple responses are a powerful element either in motivating or discouraging players, according to their degree of success in the game.[71]



Figure 6.2 Positive in-game emotions: a successful Tauren warrior moving on to the next quest in *World of Warcraft*

There are even players who find joy in destroying the game experience for others. These "grief players" are a part of every gaming community, from the early textual worlds to the game worlds of today, with hundreds of thousands of participants; more to the point, such "players" are a part of every human community. In the world of multiplayer games, these players may wreak havoc, for example, by playing only for the purpose of killing other players or stealing their property. Developers have become more and more aware of the fact that social games not only encourage people to play nicely together but also open the door for a lot of "undesirable behavior." In recent years designers have altered the configuration of games precisely to curb this brand of spiteful activity.[72] Jonas Heide Smith, in his analysis of group behavior in social games, points to the trade-off designers face between allowing a high degree of freedom and restricting action to avoid grief play. He presents indicative data of players' perceptions of different kinds of sabotage in online games, showing that they think sabotage is a significant problem as it can totally spoil their experience of the game.[73] The presence of the grief player reveals the potentially negative reasons why some people, luckily very few, are drawn to video games, and can be linked to the negative effects video game playing can have in some predisposed individuals, as explored in Chapter 9.

Taking a broader approach to the range of parameters affecting players, there is another dimension influencing the ludic experience, which, following Aycock, we call "metaculture." Metaculture includes all the factors beyond the psychological experience of playing, and is defined by a playing community. Aycock uses chess as an example, asking why the satisfaction of winning is greater at some times more than others (when playing an ex-world champion, for instance). The answer lies in the metaculture of chess, which can include everything from international rules, tournaments, and ratings, to journals about the game and the equipment used. All of these elements are significant because they help determine, for example, how important a single game can be, or how players can achieve lasting fame. For instance, the World Cyber Games (WCG) website hosts a "Hall of Fame," where pictures and small bios of the "WCG Legends" are displayed. This title "is given by WGC committee to the players who have won the Grand Final two or more times. WGC and all the world's gamers will remember them forever."[74] Winning, in this case, means much more than just playing a good game.

The metaculture of a game is an array of meanings produced and endorsed by the playing community, something that also occurs for video games, as we will see in a later section. Considering the metaculture of a game completes our understanding of the act of playing, since without it theories of framing such as Csikszentmihalyi's flow (as explained previously) provide an insufficient basis for understanding the experience of playing as a whole.

Who Plays?

You might think that the majority of video game players are maladjusted boys in their teens, but the truth is that the past few years have seen an

unprecedented widening of the player base, related to what Jesper Juul has called "a casual revolution." He quotes a report from the Entertainment Software Association that says that 65 percent of US households play video games today, and the average age of a game player is 35 years, as well as a BBC report that says that 59 percent of people between the ages of 6 and 65 play some form of video game.[75] Video games are no longer synonymous with complex and demanding AAA titles; they can also be on-screen solitaire, a round of mahjong, or Wii with the family.

Juul argues that the arcade video games of the 1980s were made for a general audience, but the field became specialized in the 1990s and early 2000s in a way that "alienated many players."[76] The operating difficulty of high-end first-person shooters and the heavy time investment required to play MMORPGs are not for everyone. But even during the years of specialization the biggest successes came from games oriented more toward the mainstream, such as *Myst* or *The Sims*. Juul's point is that lately game designers have begun designing for everyone again, and the casual games of our time "are easy to learn to play, fit well with a large number of players and work in many different situations."[77] He is referring mainly to two new trends: downloadable casual games that can be played in short bursts, like *Cake Mania*, and mimetic interfaces that invite players to use their real-world knowledge and intuition directly, such as *Guitar Hero*. It is rarely the case that games are purely casual or purely hardcore, and most games can be used in different ways (there can be hardcore play of *Bejeweled* and casual play of *Halo*, for example), but the design of a game will tend in one direction or the other.[78]

Hardcore players: People who play games that are difficult to learn and master for extended periods of time. They usually engage with games on a daily basis, and for a larger amount of time.

Perhaps the only sense in which one can meaningfully talk about casual versus **hardcore players** is when considering self-perception. Fewer people will admit to being hardcore players, given the stigma attached to it (uses too much time, is antisocial, etc.), and some people who actually play quite a lot will be hesitant even to admit to playing computer games at all. These people would much rather define themselves as casual gamers. On the other hand, some proud hardcore players are actually afraid that the current focus on casual games will dumb down their hobby.[79]

Regardless, video games are becoming a more "natural" pastime, one that fits into the lives of increasing numbers of people, and this has consequences for the types of games we enjoy and the development of the game industry.

Female Players

In order better to understand the issue of self-perception as a gamer and the position of players in relation to the game industry, we will consider a particular group of players: women. The video game industry is overwhelmingly dominated by men. If we are to fully understand the culture created by those who play video games, we must examine the role of gender in the industry.

Though there are a few well-known female designers—such as Brenda Laurel or Roberta Williams—men control both the production and

consumption ends of the industry, with the products themselves mainly targeted at a male audience. However, there is a female game audience: in the United States and Western Europe, female gamers constitute 39 percent and 25 percent, respectively, of the total number of active gamers; in Japan, 36 percent of players are women, and nearly 70 percent of all women have a game machine at home.[80]

In the past, the industry has tried to attract young female players by giving games a more girl-friendly appearance. There is the well-known case of *Ms. Pac-Man*, a game strikingly similar to *Pac-Man*, apart from the pink bow worn by the main character. Nintendo also started marketing a pink version of their Gameboy, aimed at girls even though the games themselves were the same. Now their portable console, the Nintendo DS, is available in a whole rainbow of colors, allowing both boys and girls to choose beyond stereotypes.

For many years video games based on the Barbie doll, such as *Barbie Fashion Designer*, have been typical girl best sellers, even though neutral games such as *Tetris, Myst*, or *Frogger* have allegedly enjoyed enduring success among female players. Other games that early on helped open up game culture to girls include music-based games such as *PaRappa the Rapper* or *Fluid*, dancing games such as *Spice World* or *Beatmania*,[81] and games that involve the whole body, such as Wii games. Some of the massively multiplayer online role-playing games have an important fanbase among women; according to Nicholas Yee, 16 percent of *EverQuest* players are female.[82] In recent years the ubiquitous nature of smartphones with almost unlimited supply of games have also paved the way for more gender-balanced availability of games. Games like *Candy Crush Saga* and *Hay Day* have in that sense made an impact similar to *The Sims* or *FarmVille* in drawing in new player types, especially women. Still, the controversy surrounding *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood* suggests that gender is still something that needs to be factored into the equation of game audiences, although the exact implications are still elusive. Allegedly, the Kim Kardashian game became a success because it found a way to reach the female audience not typically attracted to popular builder games like *Clash of Clans* and *Boom Beach*.

From this varied list of games, it is difficult to extract a set of characteristics typical of the games girls prefer.[83] There seem to be some games that attract both boys and girls, although the two genders display different playing strategies, as reported by Kafai in relation to the game *Where in the World Is Carmen Sandiego?* She has studied the differences in children's attitudes to video games by asking boys and girls to design games to teach mathematics and science to younger children, concluding that gender differences might be more context dependent than innate.[84] It is impossible to say if these results can be extrapolated to games in general, but they indicate the importance in empirical research of taking into account the context in which players are observed; for example, changing a parameter like the genre of the game can produce completely different results.

Nevertheless, Schott and Horrell have conducted a series of interviews with girl gamers and have been able to isolate several characteristics:

> Specifically, girl gamers identified a preference for third-person role-play games that contain animal/creature based characters rather than highly gendered human figures. In addition to these factors, games also needed to allow girl gamers the freedom to explore the virtual setting of the game. This was supported by the finding that girl gamers rejected games such as sports games and violent, combat focused games that are not open to creative interpretation.[85]

Girls in this study were also aware of the sexism in games and wished that gender representation was more balanced and realistic. A later study from 2011 stresses that it is important to distinguish between "core" gamers and "noncore" gamers. This distinction resembles the terms "casual gamers" and "hardcore gamers" but has a slightly more precise definition that focuses on classic game genres like shooters, racing, roleplaying ("core"), as opposed to small puzzle games ("noncore"). The core gamers play these at least once per week, whereas the noncore gamers may play once a week but in a different genre.

> Overall, gender remained an element of considerable importance, suggesting that men and women have distinct game playing styles. Those gender differences, however, often depend on a player's previous experience with core genres.[86]

Generally, the study did support that, for example, women had less preference for violent video games but not that women were less interested in competitive games. The study also found that noncore gamers had a preference for simpler games, but this was not a general gender characteristic. Interestingly, the study didn't find any major gender differences in relation to preference for game setting or narrative components.

Female players had a preference for customizing their avatar, which is also in line with previous perceptions. It was found that female players have a stronger preference for playing with an avatar of their own sex, whereas the same was not true for male players.

Concerns of the female players in these studies reflect the two main types of academic research into the area of gender and video games: that which deals with representation of women in video games, often working from a cultural studies or literary perspective; and that which deals with women as players of games, usually from a sociological or ethnographic perspective.

From the former, we have a number of studies that analyze the content of video games to discover how women are represented. These studies are usually very critical of the medium, finding in video games the worst kind of social prejudice and objectification of women. Their arguments are very similar to those of feminist critics dealing with cinema or television, as they concentrate on the symbolic weight of representation; common themes are

the stereotypical representation of male and female bodies and behaviors[87] or the male gaze.[88]

The case of Lara Croft, the gun-toting pin-up central character of the *Tomb Raider* series, is paradigmatic of these concerns. The character has drawn the attention of theorists for years, but their analyses have not always paid attention to the game as such.[89] Helen Kennedy's "Lara Croft: Feminist Icon or Cyberbimbo? On the Limits of Textual Analysis" summarizes these arguments, and Lara Croft's ambivalent role as both an action heroine (finally a female character with an active role in a video game!) and an eroticized object of the male gaze with a great deal of voyeuristic appeal. Kennedy argues that watching Lara is not the same as playing as Lara, that is, video games foster a "complex relationship between subject and object."[90] On this same topic, Mary Flanagan has argued that playing (that is, manipulating) Lara's body takes us a step further than watching it:

> More than the indulgence of looking at these stars within filmic worlds, we now embrace the very real pleasures of controlling these desired bodies: Lara is at the apex of a system in which looking manifests into doing, into action.[91]

On the other side of the screen, there is also significant and fruitful research into women and girls as players of video games. A seminal early work in this area is the book co-edited by Justine Cassell and Henry Jenkins, *From Barbie to Mortal Kombat: Gender and Computer Games*, which appeared in 1998 and included a series of contributions from researchers, as well as interviews with women in the game industry and players. The book paints a broad picture of the world of girls and games, going beyond stereotypes and examining what kinds of games girls play and why. It looks at games specifically produced for girls and at how girls play games that are traditionally boy-dominated. More than ten years later, Castell and Jenson suggested in a research paper that the field had not moved forward since then. Often the gender issue was ignored, browsed quickly over, or handled through simplistic and superficial models.

Since its authors are worried about girls being "left out" of the computer revolution, an aim of the book is to offer some answers as to how girls could be integrated into the world of video games without necessarily having to adopt boys' culture and instead modifying the culture itself so that there is space for everybody. The editors believed that female-run and female-oriented game companies could transform the market in what they called "the girl's game movement," something that has not happened yet, even though, as Jenkins argues, the success of games such as *The Sims* might indicate an industry shift.[92] For Jenkins, *The Sims* is an incarnation of the ideal version of a game for girls as described by Brenda Laurel:

- Leading characters are everyday people that girls can easily relate to and are as real to girls as their best friends.

- The goal is to explore and have new experiences, with degrees of success and varying outcomes.
- Play focuses on multisensory immersion, discovery, and strong story lines.
- Games feature everyday "real-life" settings as well as new places to explore.
- Success comes through development of friendships.[93]

If these features become more interesting to both girls and boys, the industry might progress toward gender-neutral gaming, according to Jenkins. We might be getting there through casual games. However, there are still significant differences in the way males and females approach play. Both girls and adult female players dedicate less time to this activity than their male counterparts. In the case of girl gamers, the explanation might lie with the scarcity of attractive game content and the girls' perception that it is a male-dominated culture.[94] This is confirmed by statistics about female players' hours of gaming, which show that younger players spend more time on games than older players.[95]

Beyond game content and player demographics, there is another important aspect to consider in relation to girls and video games: the gendering of gamespaces and gaming practices. According to Jo Bryce and Jason Rutter, public gaming spaces—namely the arcade—are typically male-dominated,[96] and research has found that women prefer playing in domestic spaces. As a result, women are less likely to play certain games, such as first-person shooters. Along with the spaces where games are played, we should also consider the formation of groups of female gamers and the development of their own communities. Bryce and Rutter present a useful introduction to the multifaceted nature of the intersection between gender and computer gaming in "Killing Like a Girl: Gendered Gaming and Girl Gamers' Visibility."[97]

In her report "Girls/Women Just Want to Have Fun: A Study of Adult Female Players of Digital Games," Aphra Kerr, after presenting empirical studies of women gamers and game producers and an analysis of gaming industry advertising strategies, concludes that women gamers are "largely invisible to the wider gaming community and producers."[98]

But why do women play? What pleasure do they derive from engaging with mostly male-oriented games? In her paper "Multiple Pleasures: Women and Online Gaming," T. L. Taylor offers an explanation based on empirical data gathered through extensive ethnographic and interview research centered on MMORPGs, arguably the favorite genre of online female gamers (with the exception of traditional games—from cards to puzzles to trivia-based games—that many people play at their workplaces[99]). Looking at *EverQuest*, Taylor found that women enjoy a very varied range of activities in the game. Some of these won't surprise us, such as socializing or exploring the game world, but other activities are typically associated with male players, including an interest in game standing and progress, identity performance, advancement in the game by way of improved skill, team sports, and combat. From this list, it might be striking to some that girls also seem to enjoy competition and that they do not abhor violence, even

stylized as it is in this game. Also revealing is the fact that female *EverQuest* players "often struggle with the conflicting meanings around their avatars," due to their stereotypical appearances, so that, while they enjoy being able to choose an original appearance (instead of a pre-made avatar), they often ignore it during play. What the success of MMORPGs demonstrates is that "games that simply focus on friendship and sociality may overlook the fact that girls are looking for games that also push them to take risks and where there is a chance to be absolutely and unequivocally dominant."[100]

With the so-called Gamergate incident in 2014, the gender discussion took on a life entirely of its own and showed that the issues surrounding gender in games are more complex than ever, and events turned grim like no one could have imagined. Events started out small with an allegedly biased review and eventually escalated into a concentrated campaign of attacks against several women in the game industry and those who defended them, including death and rape threats, hacker attacks, and the threat of a mass shooting.[101]

Gamergate expanded more broadly to involve the entire ecosystem around video games including those who develop games, those who fund them, who write about them, and who play them, just to mention some of the more important stakeholders, all broadly centered around the issue of diversity in gaming. Ultimately, it became a big ugly fight where nobody was quite sure what was up and down in a chaotic web of discussion on pretty much any digital forum invented thus far.

As the dust settled, it was argued that the discussion sparked such strong reactions because games are undergoing a transformation away from subculture and toward the mainstream. Gamergate fundamentally became a battle about what games are and what they should be, as illustrated by Leigh Alexander's Gamasutra article,[102] where she called out the community and brought the issues of sexism in the game community and, more generally, the harassment faced by women online, into the forefront of the discussion. Although it is unfair to label all gamers misogynistic, there is definitely a strong undercurrent. Game culture is today still male dominated on the inside (developers, publishers, journalists, etc.) but less so on the outside where female players are abundant albeit underserved in comparison to the male audience—something that may explain the surprise hit of the app *Kim Kardashian: Hollywood*. Although that game may not be the favorite dish that some feminists are looking for, some actually claim that it is more progressive than most games out there.[103] Changes have happened over the last 20 years with computer science broadly speaking becoming less of a male ghetto and games becoming way more mainstream. Still, we are far away from games becoming a balanced voice for society, and the game community still has strong connotations of what could be described as the smell of deep-fried chicken from the grill bar, where we found the arcade machines hosting some of the first popular video games for teenage boys. As we have seen in Chapter 4, the genres that came to prevail for a long period resembled what would in the 1950s be labeled as good activities for fresh lads—sports, guns, fighting, competition—adrenalin-pumping genres that have

now increasingly been challenged by what some gamers decry as "housewife" games like *Bejeweled, FarmVille*, or *Hay Day*.

The backlash experienced by the female members of the game industry vocal in the debate, most noticeably Zoe Quinn, Brianna Wu, and Anita Sarkeesian, revealed a strong segment of video game culture opposed to the growing diversity in games. Unfortunately, it also meant that the criticism toward the questionable ethics in a lot of game journalism never really received the attention it deserved. Game journalism is in many countries still struggling to come of age and not to be reliant on influence from major game publishers (through for example advertising) to maintain balanced reviews.[104]

Game Communities

As we have seen, video games have now become a way for people to define their identities, to find like-minded individuals, and participate in a world that merges with their "real life" in new and exciting ways. With so many motivations, and so many desires, player culture is a fascinating world, and a crucial element of understanding video games today. One way to look at player culture is to investigate the social clustering of players around their favorite games. Celia Pearce notes that communities of play have existed before video games, and the story of multiplayer games can be studied in terms of communities;[105] but now they are truly flourishing due to the Internet.

In our ever-more networked world, there is a substantial amount of research into virtual communities—which, as opposed to real-life communities, don't meet physically but over the Internet. The research on virtual communities typically focuses on MUDs and social networks of various kinds, from website fora that talk about favorite soaps to dating sites.[106] It is also worth noting that gaming communities (like all other communities) are often exclusive. A player has to prove her worth by living up to community norms and developing a certain amount of social capital. Gaming communities are also prone to some conflict, as we've seen; in addition, socializing has a negative side when people are mobbed or cannot agree about what constitutes appropriate behavior.

Game community: Players who interact with a high frequency around a game, and may develop a particular set of norms and forms of interaction.

To understand what constitutes a **game community**, let's explore the characteristics of a virtual community, as described by researcher Tom Erickson[107] (as game communities will mostly be virtual[108]). Erickson has summarized the available research on virtual communities and reached the conclusion that most definitions contain the following elements: membership, relationships, commitment, collective values, shared goods, and duration. If we apply them to a persistent online game like *EverQuest,* we will obtain some parameters to understand the kinds of communities that grow up around video games, as well as help us distinguish between them. *EverQuest* has been one of the best-selling fantasy games of all time. It was first published in 1999 and still has a significant online community;[109] because of its size and durability, it offers a good case study in the dynamics of a game community.

- *Membership*: All players must sign up for their own account in order to participate in *EverQuest*. In contrast to the vague standards of some

other communities—an online forum, for example, where people can post anonymously and come and go as they please—membership in a game like *EverQuest* is a prerequisite for entering the online world. Membership is tied to the player and not the characters, and one membership account allows a player to maintain several characters at the same time.

- *Relationships*: The fictional world of *EverQuest*, called Norrath, is governed by a set of rules, explained in the game's instructions and on numerous websites. These rules also determine the social relationships between players. A player begins the game by choosing a race and a class (profession) for his characters; this decision determines everything from how other races and classes will view them to what territories they can and cannot venture into. Relationships among races are determined partly by the fictional history of Norrath provided by the game creators, and partly by fantasy literature conventions (for example, dwarves do not like elves). The abilities of the player character also play a role, in that a higher level means a higher social status. Relationships become formalized when players organize in guilds and acquire rights and obligations toward the other members of the guild. For example, a guild might want to carry out a raid on a particular night, and need all its members to participate in order to have a chance of success; this can put pressure on the players to log on, even though they might have other real-life commitments that make it difficult. These social bonds can thus affect the real-world relationships of players.
- *Commitment and generalized reciprocity*: Commitment to *EverQuest* is simple but costly: the game demands hours of your time. Dedicated players spend a large amount of time in the fictional world, and usually expect a similar level of dedication from fellow players, especially if they adventure together in ad hoc groups or organized guilds. Generalized reciprocity means respecting the rules of the game. These rules can be "hard"—the type that game administrators will enforce; for example, the rule that you are not supposed to kill another player unless you're in a PVP (**player versus player**) server—but they can also be "soft"—either informal or unwritten; for example, you shouldn't talk "OOC" (out of character) in a guild meeting as it can annoy fellow players. Different groups of players will share different "soft" conventions.
- *Shared values and practices: EverQuest* players are mostly interested in advancing their characters (character advancement is the main goal of the informal genre of role-playing games, and thus the most common practice). Secondary goals can be anything from exploring the virtual environment to engaging in conversation.[110] Players advance their characters with very similar strategies: usually solitary quests and easy killings (rats, snakes) in the first levels, and then more complicated group quests as the levels increase. The shared values of a game community are manifested in game behavior (it is usual, for example, for experienced players to help new ones with their initial quests, and even offer them pieces of equipment as gifts) and on the websites and fora, where players discuss the game and how people should or should not behave.

Player versus player (PVP): Usually refers to a type of online role-playing game in which human players can fight each other.

- *Collective goods*: The main shared collective good is the world of Norrath, duplicated on several servers around the world. Characters also have similar ways of collecting goods; for example, by looting enemy corpses. Sometimes players trade with items from their own inventories. This collective exchange of materials was not intended by the designers of the original game,[111] since every object is supposed to be acquired by a person's "labor" in the game (by killing a monster, for example, or completing a quest). Sharing and other creative exchanges raise the interesting question of who owns the virtual goods in a game world.[112]
- *Duration*: This is one of the main issues when considering typical digital communities: can they be called communities if they do not exist all the time but only in limited time frames (for instance, through email or during sporadic chat meetings)? For some, only the persistent groups are communities, while the majority of researchers are willing to call more sporadic interactions a community. The *EverQuest* world is available 24 hours a day, seven days a week, so a player can join whenever she likes. Even if no other players are online with you, the illusion of a living community still holds, as you can nevertheless explore the world, go on individual quests, and interact with numerous characters (called "bots") controlled by the computer. The community's frontier is also extended by the player's participation in the game's metaculture, as we'll see later—out-of-game fora, in which players use email or instant messaging or Internet chat rooms to discuss various aspects of the game. Some communities go on existing even though the original game world closes, as Celia Pearce has shown.[113]

The dedicated fans of MMORPGs have created thriving game communities, but they are not alone. Other genres, particularly shooting and strategy games, have given rise to communities, growing up around games like *Counter-Strike, Quake, Star Craft*, and *Age of Empires*. The loyal fans of these games belong to clans, maintain dedicated homepages, and participate in intense discussions. Clans and guilds[114] are interesting mini-societies in which power is organized, fought for, and exerted, actions are discussed and planned, and levels of dedication are high.

The strength of game communities is often tied to the persistence of a game, or the amount of time average players dedicate to it. A committed MMORPG player can immerse herself for hundreds of hours in the many quests of the game. However, even if the game world itself is not persistent—as is the case, for example, for most shooters—the community of fans can utilize the gamespace to create a sense of continuity. Thus, in a shooter like *Battlefield 1942*, players will create individual derivations of the game with specific rules. A group of people who all play on a particular server might settle on certain rules of behavior, and ways to enforce these. For example, a group of *Battlefield 1942* players might agree that camping[115] is not allowed, even though the game rules cannot prevent it. As more and more groups follow suit, what emerges is a series of subcultures built around the game but each with its own peculiarities, which in turn increase the devotion of its members.

The fan culture has taken a new twist in recent years as more varied publishing formats have arisen. On Steam you can now buy early access to games in development, which is often done by fans to get the latest game, give input and support the game. Through Kickstarter and Indiegogo, fans can support a game even earlier—often all the way from the first visuals. They can support the game by pledging anywhere from $1 to $20,000. Hereby fans earn influence and respect by picking the right game and showing a vested interest. Backers are also usually rewarded on a tiered system, with a number of unique merchandise to demonstrate their devotion beyond just the game itself. Game developers have gone to great lengths to come up with creative rewards for early supporters of their games. This includes, for example, naming a character in the game after a backer or meeting the development team in person, which can easily cost several thousand dollars. The above relationship between players and developers resembles that known from beta testing MMORPGs, but there is a crucial difference: money. The player has actually paid a significant amount betting on the game developer's success, and sometimes has a very particular vision in mind for how the game should turn out. This can lead to conflicts between game developers and players as game development can often drag on, be completely cancelled, or take a turn in a new and unexpected direction.

What does all this accomplish? According to a study by Florence Chee and Richard Smith, game communities provide players with positive values absent from their real lives. They argue that the game helps to fulfill a need, which is not the same as saying that it creates it, and certainly presents no psychological danger for players.[116]

Cooperation and Conflict in Games

Multiplayer games are a balance of cooperation and conflict between players, a crucial point for the formation of player culture. Definitions of computer games usually stress that games imply conflict.[117] Competition can take a number of forms. It can be strictly zero-sum, as in most strategy games where you either win or die trying, or more ambiguous, as when players of a console RPG must cooperate to achieve overall goals but also compete to some extent for resources. These examples all qualify as "intra-mechanic," that is, they concern player relationships that are shaped by the actual game code.

There is also a type of conflict that is "extra-mechanic," which does not stem from the rules of the game itself (though it can be influenced by the game). It is usually this type of conflict which causes serious strife, and not, for instance, that Player A shot down Player B in a competitive game. In other words, conflict in itself is not a problem. An example will serve to illustrate the issue: soon after the 1997 release of the early MMORPG *Ultima Online*, massive tension developed between players who did not agree on the norms of behavior.[118] As one critic commented, the world soon resembled "Afghanistan after the Soviets left: unremitting random violence, feuds, continual victimization

of the weak by the strong."[119] Since then, most online game designers have usually gone to great lengths to limit the opportunities for destructive play. Often this has taken the form of severely limiting player options.

Clearly, there are infinite ways in which players may upset other players; and anecdotes from practically every online game abound. Here we shall focus on three main categories of the most common offenses—cheating, the violation of local norms, and grief play.

Although clearly relevant to an understanding of gaming, the world of cheating had received limited academic attention,[120] until Mia Consalvo published her book *Cheating: Gaining Advantage in Videogames*.[121] We can define this transgression as any behavior that gives the cheater an unfair advantage over opponents, and/or anything that runs contrary to the spirit of the game. The terms "unfair" and "spirit of the game" are clearly subjective, and make cheating itself an altogether social construction.

However, some consensus exists and the term is not used in an entirely arbitrary way. Consalvo, who has asked players themselves to define cheating, has isolated three categories: anything other than getting through the game all on your own, breaking the rules of the game (code), or cheating in relation to another human player.[122] In all cases, the advantage obtained must be somehow "unfair." If your brother was an expert *Tekken* player and you had never tried the game before, using those skills to crush you in battle would not be unfair (although it might not live up to higher ideals). Repositioning chess pieces while you were distracted, however, would constitute cheating, since it is unfair, and goes against the spirit of the game (in which strategic skill should decide the winner).

Some techniques may run against the spirit of a game without being technically unfair. These are in fact the most common transgressions. The phenomenon known as "camping" is one example. Camping refers to the less-than-brave tactic of placing one's first-person shooter character in a highly secure spot and then waiting patiently for the enemy to come close enough to be surgically dispatched. Camping is not technically unfair, since the option is equally available to the enemy (in which case the game would grind to a halt). In fact, since camping is such a successful strategy, many players will argue that it actually does not go against the spirit of the game (that is, the intentions of the designers). If so, then camping becomes a question of local norms.

Having the core rules refereed by an impartial machine, video games clearly offer far less opportunity for confusion over winning conditions than do traditional games. But despite the seeming clarity offered by a computer's algorithms, multiplayer games are still often dependent on players reaching a mutual understanding about how the game should be played. Such implicit rules are the subject of intense debate among players. Often such discussions speak directly to the question of the "spirit of the game," while at other times discussion hinges on the interpretation of specific local rules, or player actions as regards these rules.

For instance, if the player community for a real-time strategy game finds that particular civilizations are too powerful, a player who has chosen one

of these civilizations might not be accepted for entry into the game. Should the player insist strongly, she may end up being evicted from the game. Interestingly, when an implicit rule reaches a certain broad degree of consensus it is often built into the actual rules of game sequels or later games in the same genre. Consalvo, in her empirical study of cheating practices, has found that a lot of gamers cheat; it is not about subverting the game system; instead it is a way to keep playing through a game that is too difficult, boring, or plain bad.[123]

The broad category of "grief play" includes any player behavior that intentionally causes stress in another player; typically it is unrelated to the winning conditions of the game. A common example is unprovoked harassment through an in-game chat channel. Where stress-inducing behavior is a consequence of a player pursuing a personal goal, Chek Yang Foo and Elina M. I. Koivisto have suggested that the term "greed play" is more appropriate in cases where the player may be unscrupulous but his actions are not motivated by a wish to harm innocent bystanders.[124]

Grief play, in other words, can be understood as the intentional causing of distress in another player. There are gray areas, however, since all players are represented in a gamespace by some type of avatar. Thus, if one player has created an explicitly antisocial character, it can obviously be difficult to distinguish between behavior that is aimed at displeasing another player and behavior that is merely consistent with the character's identity.[125] In general, we should note that grief play is not surprising. It is simply a manifestation of deviance, a gaming parallel of real-world situations that happen every day.

Game Creativity and Metaculture

Some players do not content themselves with just the game. In-game communication with other players (in games where it exists) is not enough. And so, metaculture is born. In order to bring a game beyond the screen, so to speak, players construct elaborate out-of-game meeting places, usually virtual, where they can do anything from discussing a given game to creating ranking systems for evaluating their performances. Modding and official competitions are also group efforts, and range from fully official (for example, a "community" that is based on the game developer's own web page), to semi-official (for example, websites with formal links to developers[126]), to websites wholly independent of the game's creators. The existence of such Internet support can prove essential to the longevity of a game. So even games that have no online component (or only a weak one) may be profoundly affected by the existence of the World Wide Web.

Often dedicated players will keep a game alive long after its release (and long after the developer has turned its attention to marketing other games). An example of this is the website *Age of Kings Heaven*, centered around *Age of Empires II: Age of Kings*.[127] Whereas the original game was released in 1999, players remain active (as of early 2015) posting news stories, strategy guides and other materials, and participating in forum discussions. The

modding forum contains over 1.2 million posts, testifying to a level of player interest that goes way beyond a mere desire to play the game itself.

Such dedication among fans means more than sharing information and discussing strategies. As players congregate, they form subcultures centered around a specific game but also placing the players in the wider culture of gaming itself. For instance, avid *Halo* players can feel a sense of belonging when interacting with fellow *Halo* fans. They will develop particular subcultural slang. Such slang will only be fully intelligible to other devoted *Halo* players; it will be partly understandable by fans of other shooters, only vaguely understandable by fans of other genres (like the strategy genre), and close to unintelligible to nongamers.

Undoubtedly, game-specific lingo is a form of metaculture that emerges because it is an efficient way of communicating for the initiated. But it also highlights one's seniority within the social strata that build up around a game. Your language is a way of distinguishing between the experienced and the newcomer, and thus is a way to assert one's position. In other words, even if it was not invented for that purpose, subcultural language becomes a social stratification tool.

Leetspeak: Also referred to as 1337 sp3@k. It is a dialect of online communication (typically between gamers) which is written using certain rules of substitution (e.g. "3" for "E"), and which can be very difficult to understand for anyone who is not active in online communities.

Nowhere is this clearer than in the case of "leetspeak."[128] **Leetspeak** or just "leet" is a code (or more precisely, a cipher) which specifies alternative ways of writing English words.[129] A phenomenon such as leetspeak may well be understood as a reaction to the mainstreaming of gaming—a way to recreate some of the subcultural exclusivity enjoyed by (some) gamers in the past. Certainly one's command of leet, like any other "in-the-know" form of speech, is a signal of one's seniority within gaming.

Beyond language, there are many other creative fan practices, such as modding, as mentioned previously, the creation of walkthroughs, the writing of fan fiction, and so forth. Wirman talks about "game-related fan productivity" and distinguishes between instrumental and expressive forms, interestingly linking it to gamers' different interests and playing styles:

> role-players, players who play the game in-character and attempt to identify with it, are normally seen as interested in the backstory and narrative, while power gamers, players who aim to play as effectively as possible, concentrate on goals, such as completing game quests. In other words, role-players seem expressively productive and power gamers instrumentally productive.[130]

Productive play: Creative activities inspired by games, in which players create scenarios (mods), fiction (fan fiction, movies, machinima, etc.), or game aids (such as walkthroughs) to extend the experience of their favorite games.

A prime example of metaculture is "poaching." This term refers to any activity where fans creatively reuse content from other media. A classic example is a fan writing fiction using the characters from their favorite television series, as Henry Jenkins reports in *Textual Poachers: Television Fans and Participatory Culture*.[131] Celia Pearce has noted that video game–inspired **productive play** goes beyond poaching in other media, as sometimes it can transform the virtual worlds that have spawned the practices, as in the case of the *Uru: Ages Beyond Myst* community.[132] Andrew Burn

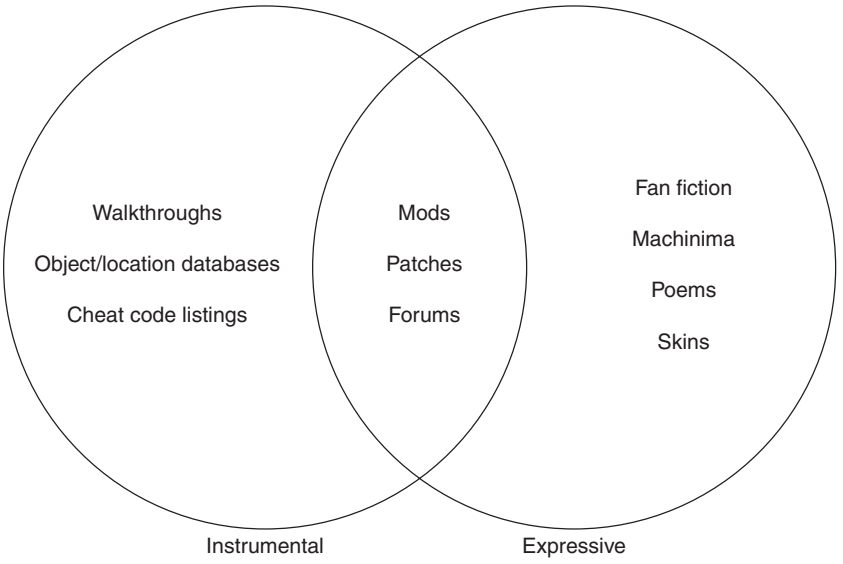


Figure 6.3 Overview of instrumental and expressive productivity

has studied different kinds of fan "poaching" based on video game texts: writing walkthroughs, creative writing that expands game universes, and manga comic strips inspired by characters or events in games.[133] Let's look at these in more detail.

The first involves the production of support texts for games, such as strategy guides, encyclopedias, or walkthroughs (a scene-by-scene reenactment of the experience of navigating your way through a game, with hints about what to do at each turn). Authors present themselves as "experts" in the community, the best-known ones will have their texts downloaded by many, and they will become authorities on a particular game. Creating these documents is an extremely time-consuming activity with uncertain rewards, since nothing guarantees that other players will endorse one's version of the game.

At the other end of the scale, creative fiction writers and manga artists who are inspired by games are not interested in gameplay at all but only in the narrative, or rather the possible narrative inspired by a particular game. They will elaborate on a character's history, retell events that happened in the game, adding explanations and feelings, and even write poetry based on their favorite characters. Stories, poems, and drawings expand the emotional universe in ways that the game cannot.[134]

Another genre of fan fiction that we could call "tribute movies" has also spread quickly across the Internet and has garnered a lot of attention in the gaming community. Some are put together with video editing programs, others with Flash, while still others are recorded using the game engines themselves, so fans can make their own animated films ("**machinima**"[135]). Fan movies reuse characters, settings, and story lines from games, usually with some humorous or ironic purpose, as in the famous "All Your Base Are Belong

Machinima: The practice of manipulating video games to produce animated films.

to Us."[136] Others take their source material to new heights; for example, Alexander Leon's *Mario Brothers* movies.[137] And the machinima genre has grown enormous since the first *Diary of a Camper* movie, based on *Quake*. All these semiotic expansions are the varied efforts of a very active fan community; the result is that favorite games are kept alive as cultural texts far longer than the usual "shelf-life" calculations of industry would predict. Players who make machinima become producers, and some cultural critics argue that this kind of fan production is more active than fan production in traditional media.[138]

"**Mods**" are modifications to or extensions of commercial games; they are created by players and then exchanged with other fans in active online fora. Though players have typically focused most of their modding efforts on shooting games, all types of video games have been modded, from *Civilization* to *Grand Theft Auto, SimCity* to *Europa Universalis* to *Amnesia: The Dark Descent*. As with poaching, an important effect of this kind of practice is that it extends the life cycle of successful games. *Half-Life*, a single-player shooter, for example, gave birth in 1999 to the most successful mod of all: a multiplayer version of the same game called *Counter-Strike*. In modifications like this one, fans can correct bugs in the game, construct new levels and maps, create new "skins" (or character avatars), and even modify certain rules so that the result can be a different game entirely.

Modding can probably be traced back to the beginning of video game history, and enthusiasts were already tinkering with Commodore 64 titles in the 1980s. But it was not until the early 1990s that the phenomenon started to spread, when the first modified versions of *Wolfenstein 3D* began flooding the Net. Game developers rapidly realized that this activity could be beneficial, and started facilitating **modders**' work in various ways. Developers began to separate the main program of a game from the media files (such as skins), so that modders would not destroy the original program. The first game to allow for this was *Doom*, in 1993.[139] Some modders have been hired by game companies, and this is increasingly recognized as an acceptable way to get a foot inside the industry.

Modder: A person that makes modifications (mods) of existing games.

But modding is not only interesting from the industry point of view. The study of modding practices can also shed light on the ways video games operate as cultural objects, producers of meaning, and discourses. Hanna Wirman's work on fan practices and their relation to gender discourses is a good example of the kinds of insights this area of study can produce.[140]

A further example of metaculture—which also furthers the connection between devoted fans and the game industry—is beta-tester events. Today, most video game producers use large numbers of "beta testers" while developing a game. The beta testers are usually dedicated players that try new games, helping both to tweak the formal rules and to seed the ground for the more informal culture in the game. From a game developer perspective, this "hotline" to the game community is crucial to ensuring the success of the game, and also to reducing the cost of testing,[141] avoiding the need to hire lots of people and pay them a salary to test the game.

As we can see, some gamers invest themselves deeply in the culture surrounding games and gaming. And as the discussion of modding above



Figure 6.4 Gizmopolitan, a fictitious magazine: productive players of *World of Warcraft*

illustrates, the resources of fan culture are becoming increasingly important in the games business and culture. However, we should be careful of assuming that these practices are more emancipatory than other kinds of media fandom. They are creative and can be seen positively; Celia Pearce talks, for example, of "productive play."[142] However, Hanna Wirman warns that:

> instead of independent DIY culture, game cultures remain very dependent on a mass market, and the most visible fan texts are altered from or based on those popular games. It is also worth noting that in the end, only a small percentage of all the players contribute to the production of new texts. While the highly productive power gamers may appear to

occupy the most extreme position of a cocreator, even they work within the varying economic and legal boundaries and regulations set by global corporations.[143]

e-Sports: The name for video gamers who compete professionally in the most popular games. Also referred to as cyberathletes.

E-Sports

The last area of metaculture we will consider also happens in the shadow of the game industry: the professionalization of play. Just like those who play "physical" sports (for lack of a better way to differentiate), video game "athletes" train by playing a game (or games), find corporate sponsorship, enter gaming tournaments, and win prizes and recognition. As early as 1999, the Descent 3 Championship Tournament had a $50,000 grand prize,[144] and since 2000 the World Cyber Games (WCG) have been held. There are many other championships, but this is the only one where people from six continents play against each other. E-Sports is more evolved in Asia, but the Western world has been catching up during the last years.

Already in 2007, WCG boasted of "a rapidly growing international Olympics in which nearly one million players compete against one another for the title of world champion in separate events."[145]

Many countries now have their own associations and leagues, such as the E-Sports Entertainment Association (ESEA), which organizes tournaments and serves as an information hub for teams and sponsors. In 2007, the ESEA described itself as follows:

> E-Sports EA was created to help promote professional gaming and mitigate the risk and uncertainty that surrounds much of the gaming community. We are creating the infrastructure needed for professional gaming teams, players, news sources, and other mediums that are needed to develop gaming into an attractive marketing tool. Through strategic partnerships and affiliate programs, companies will be able to use different gaming outlets to promote products and services and in turn, allow teams to compete in events around the world.[146]

In 2018 just shy of 400 million spectators watched, and the audience is expected to grow with another 15 percent next year. As the audience grows especially driven by better streaming and service like Twitch, so does the revenue. The commercialization of the culture around e-Sports is projected to surpass two billion US dollars within five years.[147]

We also see that sports clubs are joining the area with parallel e-Sports teams, which seems to be driven by the massive audience interest. Apart from helping their members by providing "lessons" on how to play each game or giving them the chance of posting videos of their best game sessions online, the organization has a clear market goal, aimed at making e-Sports as big as traditional sports:

> Spectators fly into different locations just to be amongst the best players, and watch them compete. Media coverage is beginning to catch on, from

> traditional news venues like CNN, ABC, and the New York Times to more focused coverage like PC Gamer and Tech TV. With an ever-growing industry in our hands, we must keep feeding the fuel to fire. There is no limit to where competitive gaming will lead to.[148]

From these quotes it is clear that money is still a paramount concern, even when the targeted audience is dedicated gamers. And the cash prizes awarded at the end of a tournament are no doubt a primary motivation for some of these players. But we should not let simple capitalism obscure what is at work here, since gaining fame and glory through playing is an incentive as important as money, if not more so. However, so far, the academic interest has been surprisingly small especially compared to the commercial interest.[149]

The exact definition of e-Sports is still contested, not to mention whether it is even a sport, which continues to be debated.[150] Wagner in 2006 first defined e-Sports as "an area of sport activities in which people develop and train mental or physical abilities in the use of information and communication technologies."[151]

Later researchers have contested this definition as it uses sports without examining the concept in greater detail. Seth, Manning, Keiper, and Olrich (2016) stressed that e-Sports usually is performed online, and under organized formats that is a more fitting starting point. In a closer look they examine whether e-Sports qualifies as a sport. They go through the prerequisites: organized, competitive, skill-based, physical, broad following, and institutionalization.[152] Despite exhibiting a lot of the necessary characteristics and the potential to acquire the missing ones they conclude that e-Sports are not sports. Today e-Sports don't have an institutionalized format that a typical sports discipline will have built over centuries, but the biggest challenge is the lack of gross motor skills (as opposed to fine motor skills). As we will see later indeed e-Sports players stress the physical strain but fundamentally e-Sports involves entirely different muscle groups compared to any other activity typically recognized as sports. In an in-depth study of 26 e-Sports players, the physical strain related to the game exercise is stressed, and they see it akin to sports. They also stressed that the human versus human element and spectator element was a crucial part of the experience—setting it aside from "just" playing video games.[153]

Whether e-Sports may become a "real" sport may change as virtual reality evolves in the future with new interfaces, and e-Sports is consolidated with rules and organizations remains to be seen.

Still, the organized competitions in e-Sports give players the chance to excel at something that might be frowned upon by their families or the general public but that in this way becomes legitimized as a desirable skill and a worthy enterprise.

Is Game Culture Escapism, a Mirror, or Simply Work?

Another group of professional players is the people who "work" in virtual worlds, advancing characters and amassing wealth that they sell to others afterwards for real currency, as explored by Julian Dibbell in his *Play*

Money.[154] The economy of MMORPGs extends into the real world, raising moral and ethical questions related to players' behavior.

We would like to end this chapter by highlighting that player activity and the culture that grows up around video games is not separate from reality, or dismissible as escapism. Gamer activity in its many forms points to the tensions of creative production that characterize the early twenty-first century: the cultural status of the medium, its public perception, and the transitions between play and labor, which Julian Kücklich has aptly named "playbour,"[155] are signs and symptoms of bigger currents in society.

And these meaning-creating frameworks carry implications for the "real world," something that becomes apparent in the struggles around player avatar creation and ownership. What, for example, is an avatar? Is it comparable to a chess piece, or is it in fact an extension of the player, like a virtual limb? The present generation of MMORPGs highlighted the problem, as it became increasingly clear that their status as games (in the magic circle sense) was anything but clear-cut. The status of player activity in these worlds is contested. Does it constitute work (and is it therefore taxable and protected by standard laws) or is it innocent play? The license agreements a user must sign before playing usually take the latter position—not surprisingly, since manufacturers want to make it as easy as possible for players to do nothing more than play. But obviously when they do so players can be spending significant amounts of time and resources living in the game world—building characters, acquiring objects, and anything else they can think of. Many players attach a certain value—even if just gamer's pride—to their activity.

And others agree. Trading websites like eBay serve as markets for game objects and characters (often traded at high real-dollar prices). The monetary value of in-game activities can actually be measured precisely. In *EverQuest* during 2001, the characters in the game combined to produce an annual per capita GNP (gross national product) of $2,266, roughly the same as that of Russia.[156] While this inspired dramatic headlines, we should be clear that this does not mean that *EverQuest* is a rich nation (the number of inhabitants is too small). Giving a rough estimate, Edward Castronova has suggested that the combined economies of all virtual worlds may have an impact on the global economy comparable to that of Namibia or Macedonia.[157]

There are, however, other signs that many virtual worlds cannot be kept separate from real-world influences and legislation. In South Korea more than half of all reported cybercrimes in the first half of 2003 were related to online gaming.[158] In late 2003, a Chinese court ruled that the developers of the online game *Hongyue* were liable for the losses of virtual property suffered by a player. The aggrieved party (one Li Hongchen) argued that the developers had neglected server security, leaving his account vulnerable to hacking.[159]

Meanwhile in 2003, in *The Sims Online*, professor of philosophy Peter Ludlow discovered an in-game brothel with a number of employees played by underage girls. The story made headlines in the *New York Times*, and soon after Ludlow's account was canceled, on the grounds of having advertised

his blog within the game (the game developers do not allow the in-game advertisement of real-life goods or services).[160]

Such events highlight the difficulty of separating two spheres of reality, and make it still harder to maintain magic circle notions of the status of games. Players live between the two worlds. In an influential paper on the topic of the application of legal thought to games, Greg Lastowka and Dan Hunter note: "Though virtual worlds may be games now, they are rapidly becoming as significant as real-world places where people interact, shop, sell, and work."[161]

To conclude, we would adhere to T. L. Taylor's words: "My call then is for nondichotomous models. One of the biggest lessons in Internet studies is that the boundary between online and offline life is messy, contested, and constantly under negotiation."[162] Games are of course designed and produced industrially, and have meaning as aesthetic artifacts, but they are transformed by players, who are producers of culture,[163] and how this happens is likely to occupy game scholars for many years.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- Think about your media consumption. What do you expect from different media, such as newspapers, books, music, television, and film? Compare them to video games: what can other media forms do that video games can't, and what can video games do that other media can't?
- Why do you think sections of the public are so worried about the violent content in video games? What is your perception of video game violence?
- Why do people play? Make a list of the different motivations mentioned by students in your class and see which are the most common.
- Think about your identity as a player. Do the people close to you know you play video games? Why, or why not? Is it something you talk about with new people you meet?
- What kind of feelings do you experience when playing games? How do they relate to other players? How is playing games different from other kinds of socializing in this respect?
- Discuss the differences between games that require heavy participation in a community and those played casually. What defines a player as a hardcore rather than a casual gamer?
- Pick a few recent games you all know and discuss how they represent women, and what the female characters can do in the game. Do women like to play them—why, or why not?
- Does your online (video game) life affect your offline life? If yes, how? If not, why not?
- Have you ever created something inspired by a game (e.g. fan fiction, a mod, a walkthrough)? Discuss why players engage in production practices based on their favorite games and what they get out of it.

RECOMMENDED GAMES

America's Army—The game showed how games were becoming more mainstream, and could have an impact on society. Allegedly boosted the number of recruits to the US Army.

Counter-Strike—Began as a mod of *Half-Life* rather than a fully-fledged game. It ended up paving the way for the success of modding—and in the process changed the face of computer games. Now, players can alter computer games quite dramatically. Also, the game is among the top three played e-Sports games.

DOTA 2—The game grows out of *Warcraft III*, and is a multiplayer online arena. Each player controls a hero and cooperate with their team to protect their own base and ultimately destroying the opponents base to claim victory.

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NOTES

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2. King and Krzywinska, 2006, p. 38.
3. McLuhan, 1964, p. 199.
4. In his book *Distinction*; Bourdieu, 1987.
5. An example of this might be the popularity of "slash fiction," as examined by Henry Jenkins in *Textual Poachers: Television Fans and Participatory Culture* (1992). This is a particular kind of fan fiction depicting homosexual love between TV or film characters that did not exist in the original; for example, between Captain Kirk and Spock in *Star Trek*.
6. Jenkins, 2005.
7. Flanagan, 2009, p. 1.
8. Flanagan, 2009, p. 2.
9. Dietz, 1998, p. 438.
10. Dietz, 1998.
11. Ramírez, Forteza, Hernando, and Martorell, 2002, replicating Provenzo, 1991.

12. Ramírez et al., 2002.
13. Bogost, 2007, 2008.
14. Wardrip-Fruin, 2009.
15. Flanagan, 2009.
16. Bogost, 2007, p. ix.
17. Bogost, 2007, p. ix.
18. See also a paper written by the game's designers: Zyda et al., 2003.
19. Bogost, 2007, p. 77.
20. Bogost, 2007, p. 78.
21. Wardrip-Fruin, 2009, p. 411.
22. Sicart, 2009, p. 49.
23. Sicart, 2009, p. 89.
24. Sicart, 2009, p. 102.
25. Evans, 2001.
26. Sutton-Smith, 1997.
27. Evans, 2001, pp. 164–180.
28. See Flanagan, 2009, p. 60.
29. Flanagan, 2009, p. 252.
30. On the controversy, see, for example Kent, 2001, pp. 90–92.
31. Consider, for instance, the following quotation from a 1981 *Newsweek* article: "For all their winning ways, video games have been bombarded by controversy. Critics contend that they squander allowances and study time, glorify violence and encourage everything from compulsive gambling to tendinitis (*Space Invaders* wrist). Taking a cue from the pool-troubled elders of the mythical River City, communities from Snellville, Ga., to Boston have recently banned arcades or restricted adolescent access; one legal challenge to the ordinances will be heard by the Supreme Court this week" (Langway, 1981).
32. An example of this is "Video Games and Aggressive Thoughts, Feelings, and Behavior in the Laboratory and in Life," Craig A. Anderson and Karen E. Dill's 2000 study of the effects of violent games. The study begins: "On April 20, 1999, Eric Harris and Dylan Klebold launched an assault on Columbine High School in Littleton, Colorado, murdering 13 and wounding 23 before turning the guns on themselves." The authors thus framed their work as part of the investigation into what caused the tragic school shooting.
33. Griffiths, 2005.
34. The arcade version was released in 1992.
35. Quoting the *Montreal Gazette*, August 7, 1994.
36. Gagne, 2001.
37. www.esrb.org/.
38. A trade group for American game publishers founded in 1994.
39. "Each ESRB rating is based on the consensus of at least three specially trained raters who view content independently of one another. ESRB raters work on a part-time basis and are recruited from one of the most culturally diverse populations—the New York metropolitan area. They must be adults, and typically have experience with children through their profession, education or by being parents or caregivers themselves. They are not required to have advanced skills as computer and video game players since their job is to review content and determine its age-appropriateness, not to assess how challenging or entertaining a particular game is to play. To ensure their objectivity ESRB raters are kept anonymous, and they are not permitted to have any ties to or connections with any individuals or entities in the computer/video game industry" (from the ESRB website, at www.esrb.org/ratings/faq.jsp#14, accessed October 5, 2011).
40. Established in 2003 by the Interactive Software Federation of Europe (ISFE), the trade group for European game publishers. PEGI rates games according to age and by assigning content labels, much as the ESRB does. The difference between the two organizations (apart from the different ratings assigned to individual games) is that the ESRB has agreements with some companies, who pledge not to sell adult-rated games to children. PEGI ratings are entirely voluntary and not enforced by European law, meaning children will be able to buy adult-rated games. Thirty countries use the PEGI rating system. Germany

does not, and has its own, more strict rules for video game content.
41. About this and other controversies, see, for example, GAMEINFORMER, 2006.
42. Developed by Dutch modder Patrick Wildenborg.
43. Around $24.5 million, according to the company's own estimate; GameSpot, 2006.
44. See, for example, BBC News, 2004.
45. See, for example, Good and McWhertor, 2011.
46. Philips, 2011.
47. Jenkins, 2000.
48. Williams, 2003a, 2003b.
49. Williams, 2003a, p. 241.
50. Williams, 2003a, p. 242.
51. See, for example, Schiesel, 2007b.
52. Rutter and Bryce, 2006, pp. 149–150, 162. A good introduction to this approach is "The Use of Games," Chapter 5 in Torill Mortensen's, 2009 book *Perceiving Play: The Art and Study of Computer Games*. The book as a whole is also remarkable for its player focus.
53. Estallo, 1995.
54. Morris, 1999.
55. Wright et al., 2002.
56. Csikszentmihalyi, 1990, p. 67.
57. Csikszentmihalyi, 1990, pp. 46–67.
58. By this we mean that the game's challenges usually start small, giving the player a chance to get used to the interface and the rules, and gradually become more and more difficult as the player masters the game. For example, you can begin as a warrior character in *World of Warcraft* by killing boars with your sword while you learn how the combat system works; as you go up in level, the enemies become more powerful and you need to use more weapons in more complex ways.
59. To this, we could add the fact that video games are different, so that the pleasures of playing *Donkey Kong* are very different from those afforded by a game like *Anarchy Online*. The joy of successful hand-eye coordination in a platform game has nothing (or very little) to do with that of performance in a role-playing game, even though both activities could prompt players to enter a state of flow.
60. McGonigal, 2011, p. 3.
61. McGonigal, 2011, p. 41.
62. McGonigal, 2011, p. 49.
63. Turkle, 1995. Turkle's book contains extensive empirical information in the form of stories told by participants in multi-user dungeons (MUDs) and role-playing games of various kinds. Other works containing several essays touching on this topic are Williams, Hendricks, and Winkler, 2006; Williams and Smith, 2007.
64. Waskul, 2006, p. 35.
65. Williams et al., 2006; Williams and Smith, 2007.
66. Mortensen, 2007, p. 188.
67. Järvinen, 2008.
68. Particularly his PhD thesis; Leino, 2010.
69. Järvinen, 2008, p. 234.
70. Leino, 2009.
71. Baron, 2004.
72. Talin, 2002.
73. Smith, 2003.
74. WCG, 2010.
75. Juul, 2010, p. 8.
76. Juul, 2010, p. 2.
77. Juul, 2010, p. 5.
78. Juul, 2010, p. 55.
79. Juul, 2010, p. 62.
80. Krotoski, 2004.
81. Schott and Horrell, 2000.
82. Yee, 2001.
83. In Jesper Juul's research on the casual game portal Gamezebo, 93 percent of his survey respondents were female; see Juul, 2010, p. 154. This could be an isolated case or it could reflect the self-selection bias of surveys, but it could also be an indicator that casual gaming is attractive to women.
84. Kafai, 1998.
85. Schott and Horrell, 2000, p. 50. This is consistent with the findings of a report carried out by ELSPA (the Entertainment and Leisure Software Publishers Association), also based on in-depth interviews with women players. Reasons for women's satisfaction with games were "The

presence of a good plot, rich characterisations, choice in how they pursue goals, freedom of self-expression, novelty in challenges, immersion in atmospheric virtual environments, pick-up-and-play capabilities and flexibility" (Krotoski, 2004).

86. Vermeulen, Looy, Courtois, and Grove, 2011.
87. Dietz, 1998; Ramírez et al., 2002.
88. Carr, 2002; Flanagan, 1999.
89. Cassel and Jenkins, 1998; O'Riordan, 2001.
90. Kennedy, 2002.
91. Flanagan, 1999, p. 78.
92. Jenkins, 2000.
93. Jenkins, 2001.
94. Schott and Horrell, 2000.
95. Krotoski, 2004.
96. "Public gaming spaces such as gaming competitions or LAN parties follow similar patterns and can therefore easily be considered to be masculine—i.e. male dominated—spaces. This perception contributes to a constraint on female access and participation in public gaming activities. Such exclusion may be reinforced by the stereotypical and offensive behaviour of males towards females in public gamespaces ranging from belittlement as 'only girls,' to patronising female competitors through the well-meaning provision of prize giving, or objectification via the display of pornography at the event" (Bryce and Rutter, 2002, p. 249).
97. Bryce and Rutter, 2002.
98. Kerr, 2003, p. 270.
99. Research indicates that women aged between 35 and 49 "spend more time on online games than any other demographic," referring to the very lucrative online games market of puzzle, card, and trivia-based portals; see Krotoski, 2004, p. 12.
100. Taylor, 2003a, quoting Funk and Buchman.
101. Kain, 2014.
102. Alexander, 2014.
103. http://uk.businessinsider.com/why-kim-kardashian-hollywood-app-is-successful-2015-3?r=US.
104. Nieborg and Sihvonen, 2009.
105. Pearce, 2009, pp. 3–15.
106. See Bell, 2001, pp. 92–110.
107. Erickson, 1997.
108. Even though there is some real-life interaction when people meet physically to play; for example, in championships or conventions.
109. Now both *EverQuest* and *EverQuest II* continue to cater for players, in that they maintain their servers, are open for subscription, and regularly release expansions. However, Sony Online Entertainment doesn't publish data on the current size or composition of its player base.
110. As Richard Bartle describes in relation to the different styles people adopt while playing; Bartle, 1996.
111. Even though trading was later allowed for *EverQuest II* (2005).
112. Taylor, 2002.
113. In *Communities of Play: Emergent Cultures in Multiplayer Games and Virtual Worlds*, Pearce follows the "Uru Diaspora," a community of players of a closed-down world moving across different virtual worlds in search of a new home; Pearce, 2009.
114. These words are usually synonyms, referring to an organized group of players that act together in the game. Some games call them guilds and others clans.
115. For an explanation of "camping," see the next section, on "Cooperation and Conflict in Games."
116. Chee and Smith, 2003.
117. In their account of game design fundamentals, Salen and Zimmerman write, as mentioned earlier, that "a game is a system in which players engage in an artificial conflict, defined by rules, that result in a quantifiable outcome" (2004, p. 80). Similarly, Elliot Avedon and Brian Sutton-Smith define games as "an exercise of voluntary control systems, in which there is a contest between powers, confined by rules in order to produce a disequilibrial outcome" (1971, p. 7). Some

definitions do leave out conflict, e.g. Juul, 2003b.
118. Kim, 1998; King and Borland, 2003.
119. Rollings and Adams, 2003, p. 527.
120. Andy Kuo's student paper, "A (Very) Brief History of Cheating," is often referred to; see also Kücklich, 2004.
121. Consalvo, 2007.
122. Consalvo, 2007, pp. 87–92.
123. Consalvo, 2007, p. 95.
124. For example, "a player persistently camps a high level mob for an item he wants. But because his character isn't advanced enough, this mob kills the player, and proceeds to kill other neighbouring players. The others are unhappy and feel their gaming is being affected, but this player refuses to leave the area and continues to fight the high level mob, as he wants that item" (Foo & Koivisto, 2004, p. 2).
125. See King and Borland, 2003, pp. 161–162.
126. Such as http://heavengames.com.
127. http://aok.heavengames.com.
128. Sherblom-Woodward, 2002.
129. Leetspeak, originating, tellingly, from a version of the word "elite," works mainly through a series of specific alternative spellings (like using "z" instead of "s" in certain circumstances) and the liberal use of non-alphabetic characters to stand for (more or less similarly shaped) letters. Thus "leet" itself is often written "l33t," "ub3r" means über, and "newbie" is often written "n00b."
130. Wirman, 2009, 4.8.
131. Jenkins, 1992.
132. Pearce, 2009, p. 156.
133. Buckingham, Carr, Burn, and Schott, 2005.
134. By UNSC Trooper, posted in July 2007 to: http://halosn.bungie.org/fanfic/?story=UNSC_Trooper0704071531331.html.
135. See Lowood, 2006 or Jones, 2006, among others. Machinima as a form of fan creativity is in itself a big topic in game scholarship.
136. This movie is based on the 2001 Internet craze that saw gamers quoting the often nonsensical sentences from the Japanese video game, *Zero Wing*. The game's terrible English translation turned it into a cult object, and fans started altering photographs from all sorts of situations to include the sentence "All Your Base Are Belong to Us," and the pictures were exchanged and commented upon in many fora. Eventually, a series of these pictures were compiled in a Flash movie that was downloaded thousands of times; www.planettribes.com/allyourbase/AYB2.swf (accessed October 15, 2011).
137. These feature the famous Nintendo brothers Mario and Luigi, in original sprites (two-dimensional figures) from the game, as they engage in an epic journey to save Princess Peach. The five movies create a surprisingly palpable sense of drama, as the cartoonish, almost detail-less brothers are given gravitas by the original dialogue and emotional music. The author, who posted the first movie as a joke in 2003, was very surprised by their success. Available at his website at www.alxlen.com.
138. Jones, 2006.
139. Sotamaa, 2003, pp. 4–6. Sotamaa's works present a thorough examination of modding varieties and the academic interest in modding.
140. For her PhD thesis on female gamers' fan production and female gamer identity, see Wirman, 2010.
141. Postigo, 2003.
142. Pearce, 2009, pp. 155–175.
143. Wirman, 2009, 7.4.
144. Morris, 1999.
145. www.esportsea.com/.
146. www.worldcybergames.com/6th/inside/WCGC/WCGC_structure.asp, retrieved June 3, 2007.
147. Global e-Sports Report, 2019.
148. www.esportsea.com/.
149. Vera and Terrón, 2018.
150. Freeman and Wohn, 2017
151. Wagner, 2006, p. 440.
152. Seth et al., 2016.

153. Freeman and Wohn, 2017.
154. Dibbell, 2006.
155. Hjorth, 2011.
156. Castronova, 2001.
157. Castronova, 2004.
158. Ward, 2003.
159. Lyman, 2003.
160. Harmon, 2004.
161. Lastowka and Hunter, 2004.
162. Taylor, 2006, p. 153.
163. "Consider the range of material productions players are engaged in: the creation of game guides, walkthroughs, answers to frequently asked questions (FAQs), maps, object and monster databases, third-party message boards and mailing lists, play norms, server guidelines, modifications, plug-ins, strategies and strategy guides, auctions/trading, tweaks to user interfaces (UI), macro sharing, fanfic, game movies, counter-narratives, comics, and fan gatherings" (Taylor, 2006, p. 155).